Types of competition

The Competitive Exclusion Principle covers two main types of competition. Intraspecific competition is between individuals of the same species and ensures the survival of the fittest, so that only the healthiest individuals—or those best adapted to a particular environment—will breed. The second type is interspecific: competition between two different species that rely on the same resources. The most important of these will be the “limiting resource,” the one that both require in order to breed. Ecologists make a further two distinctions. Interference is when two organisms fight directly with each other over a limited resource, such as a mate or a preferred food. Exploitation is indirect competition, such as stripping out a resource so there is none left for the competitor; this can be seen in plants, when a species’ uptake of nutrients or water is more efficient than that of its neighbors.

See also: Evolution by natural selection • Ecological niches • Animal ecology • The ecosystem • The ecological guild • Niche construction • Invasive species